

"THE MASJID CANNOT BE

Sitting in his drawing room, wearing a kurta that met the approval of daughter Pratibha, surrounded by family photographs and paintings of Lord Krishna, BJP prime ministerial candidate L.K. Advani spoke to Executive Editor S. PRASANNARAJAN and Assistant Editor PRIYA SAHGAL about his book and perhaps an unfinished last chapter.

Q. When did you start writing the book, after the prime ministerial candidate announcement or before?

A. I had started the book much earlier. The prologue begins with Independence Day, August 15, 2007. The announcement came recently, in December.

Q. Well, you are a very hardworking person.

A. (Laughs) No, not that hardworking either.

Q. You have held back some interesting encounters.

A. Someone has said that there is no *masala* in it. I said if you see my book on the Emergency even then I was told that there is no anger in it. Therefore I said, maybe there is no anger or bitterness in my temperament.

Q. After reading the book one feels that one has come to know you better. For someone so articulate, why was there a communication gap between you and India?

A. The image of fanaticism...I acquired this after the Rath Yatra. Prior to that I had the image of a person devoted to the organisation but not a mass leader like Vajpayeeji. The Rath Yatra somehow changed this. Though I often felt uneasy that a man in public life should acquire an image which does not conform to reality, there were colleagues who said it is good. Vajpayeeji has a liberal image and you have the image of a hardliner. It doesn't hurt the party. (Smiles)

Q. What made the same people who made you step down as party chief two years ago turn to you as their prime ministerial candidate?

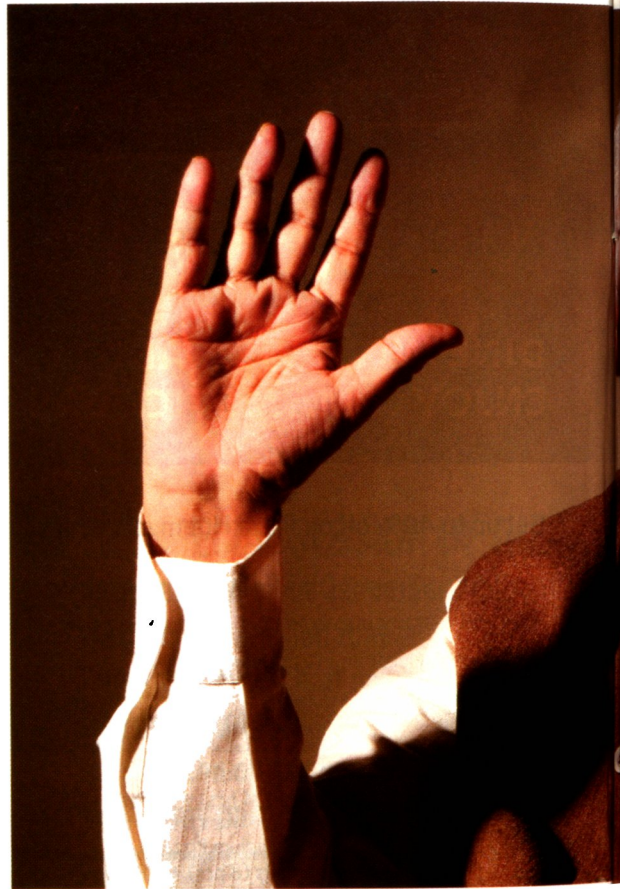
A. I don't think there was any particular turning point. Over time, I am sure they felt that elections are coming and in this age of mass communication, apart from policy and ideology it is important whom you project as a leader.

Q. How does it feel to be the singular leader of BJP?

A. It is incidental that I read a book by Sigmund Freud recently on the meaning of life. It says that unhappiness/happiness are emotions related only to the present whereas meaning is something that is related to the past, the present and to the future. And though that author says you can either have happiness or meaning in your life, I have been fortunate in having abundance of happiness and meaning in my life. I found meaning in my life at the age of 14 when I joined RSS. My family particularly has made me very happy.

Q. You have to some extent been a victim of some uncharitable comparison with Vajpayee.

A. I have been an admirer of his ever since I met him. He created in me a complex as far as speaking was concerned. For many years I could not address a public meeting. I could speak in the Parliament but not to tens of thousands in front of me and hold them spell bound as Vajpayeeji does. He is



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remarkable. I can't do it.

Q. But you have done it.

A. People like JP are heard not because they are orators, but because they have something to convey. They have a stature in public life which makes what they say important. In fact when Atalji tried to persuade me to become party president I said I can't because I don't know how to speak. He said was Deen Dayalji an orator? But we all listened to him because he had something to say.

Q. There is a perception that while Vajpayee has got things very easily you have had to struggle.

A. In my party no one has got anything easily.

Q. But you made him prime minister.

A. My perception was that it was in the party's best interests that he should be the leader. It was not an act of sacrifice on my part as some people have projected.

Q. Most of the issues you touch in the book still remain unresolved, like cultural nationalism.

A. I was hopeful that the Ayodhya issue would be resolved.